

## **Who I Am as a Mediator: A Personal Reflection**

*Mediation and Conflict Resolution | Final Reflective Paper*

### **Introduction**

This paper is my reflection on what I've learned about myself in this mediation course as a communicator, as a developing practitioner and as one who engages in conflict in daily life. It incorporates the material from the True Colors personality assessment, a role-play mediation activity and the theoretical material presented throughout the semester using positions versus interests. This paper is not a summary of mediation theory but a discussion of how much I have internalized where I am strong, where I need to become stronger and how I plan to apply my new knowledge about mediation in the future.

### **My Mediator Style: The True Colors Assessment**

My high scores were Orange (20), Blue (15), Gold (5) and Green (10) in the True Colors Word Sort. I am mostly Orange personality type, meaning I like action, I want to be spontaneous and I want to be engaged in direct involvement. In mediation the corollary of this is that I tend to build momentum and avoid impasse which is good when parties are stuck but can become a bad thing if they need more time to emotionally work through the issues before they're ready for negotiations. In our role play, at times I was tempted to hurry to a solution before both parties had the chance to voice their concerns.

My secondary Blue colour makes good sense with the Orange. Blue is a color of sympathy, kindness and a sincere connection that makes people feel listened to and encourages trust in the parties making it easier for them to be honest with each other. When I was fully engaged in the

role play, I was able to defuse the situation more effectively by using my empathetic nature and instincts as opposed to any technique. My highest score is Green which indicates a new analytical dimension yet to be explored and the lowest score is Gold which implies that my procedural thinking is not rigid, as I think of mediation as a human process.

### **Strengths, Weaknesses and the Role-Play Experience**

One of the most informative and useful experiences from the course was playing the role of Chris in the neighbor dispute. While the statement "this is a free country and Pat has no right to interfere" was Chris's position, what was actually going on was that playing guitar was Chris's main way to deal with his high blood pressure and anxiety. That underlying interest only came to light as the mediation got beyond the surface level argument. This made Mary Parker Follett's orange sisters story real in a way that a mere reading couldn't. So, no one asked why Pat needed the orange and no one asked why Chris needed the orange either. They just fought positionally. As soon as the dialogue moved from jobs to needs, resolution was possible.

My mediation strengths are related to communication, empathy and energy. I can engage in emotionally charged conversations without discomfort and feel invested in helping people feel heard by reading a room. My faults are obvious as well. The most important is patience. I tend to speed up towards the resolution which can be a stopgap for the emotional parties they have to go through first. I am efficient but my straightforwardness needs to be carefully calibrated in order to maintain neutrality. My free-spiritedness is another trait whereby sometimes I act on impulse when perhaps it's better to have a more systematic approach. I don't take it for granted to have neutrality, I make up my mind fast and it takes a conscious effort to be neutral.

## **Career, Personal Applications and Plans for Development**

This Course can be applied to skills beyond the formal mediation room setting. In my personal relationships, I have already started to move away from positional thinking to interest-based thinking which has resulted in how I view disagreements and ask myself who is right but what does each person want and need and whether there are actually conflicts? The mediation skills have wide cross-over applications to a variety of professional areas such as management, social services, community development and education. I can't help but be intrigued by the job of mediators to think more than just about the conflict that comes to the table but about building communities that can still have conversations before things get out of hand.

The first skill I want to practice more aggressively is Active listening. That is the ability to sit and listen and not fill the space with searching for something to do. I also know that I need to examine my biases more closely: for example, I have a bias that I can quite quickly decide on who's being sensible in a fight. I've been lucky with the True Colors concept as it has already proven to me that different True Colors will have different ways of dealing with conflict and that as an Orange, I'm direct and forthright; a method that isn't universal and can't just be applied to the mediation process. Beyond self-awareness, I will gain supervised practice and observation opportunities specifically in the areas of family and community mediation where the emotional aspects and power dynamics are prominent. This course has been a good foundation but it cannot replace learning that takes place when someone is sitting in front of you who is really in conflict and at that moment you know what to say.

## **Conclusion**

I would say this course has helped me to understand that conflict is not about winning or losing but about navigating it in a way that is skillful, empathetic and respectful of those involved. True Colors assessment provided me with a vocabulary for my natural tendencies. The role play provided me with a felt sense of what it feels like to have a position and conceal an interest. Readings and doctrinal exposition made those experiences relate to larger principles of practice. I am not finished with this course; I am in fact ready to start; willing to do the kind of mediation that can help individuals and people in general to stay in relationship when relationship is difficult.